

A&O Shearman

Complete firm and application research — merger & financials, practice areas, clients, legal tech, culture, CSR, apprenticeship structure, and personal application notes.

Role: Solicitor Apprenticeship (6 years)
Location: London
Salary: £28,000 + £3,000 sign-on bonus
Deadline: 18 February
University partner: BPP University
Qualification: LLB + SQE
International secondment probability: ~52%

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1. Firm Overview & Merger

A&O Shearman was formed through the transatlantic merger of Allen & Overy and Shearman & Sterling. It is positioned as a new industry leader with unmatched experience, a unique culture, and truly global capabilities — providing clients with world-class integrated solutions and unparalleled regional experience in an increasingly complex commercial and regulatory environment.

The firm was carefully designed to deliver, at the highest level, what the firms' respective clients and colleagues said they were seeking and would find nowhere else. Feedback received both externally and internally has been exceedingly positive, and clients are eager to unleash the combined power of the new firm.

- A&O Shearman was built to achieve exceptional outcomes for clients, and we now look forward to demonstrating that worldwide.*

— Firm leadership statement
- A deep commitment to excellence, collaboration, and innovation. I know of no other firm in the world that can combine our market coverage, depth of experience, and innovative approach.*

— Firm leadership statement
- Our ability to bring diverse perspectives, backgrounds, and skills to clients puts A&O Shearman in a class of its own.*

— Firm leadership statement

The firm is the first fully integrated global elite firm, with approximately 7,000 people and nearly 4,000 lawyers, including around 800 partners, across 28-29 countries and roughly 50 offices. It has the depth of experience and diversity of talent to operate at the forefront of business across every industry sector, market and geography, and is the only firm equally fluent in U.S. law, English law, and the laws of the world's most dynamic markets. Its strength comes from global capability and an unyielding standard of excellence, supported by deep local roots, relationships, experience and knowledge.

2. Financial Performance

First full-year revenue post-merger	£2.9 billion (~\$3.7 billion)
Significance	A concrete performance indicator that the merger and the integrated global practice model is paying off financially and competitively — not just a proof of scale, but proof the strategic bet is working.
M&A deal value led	More than £2.2 trillion

A&O Shearman isn't only a global law firm — it executes and leads some of the most complex strategic transactions across infrastructure investment, pensions, private capital and technology. Work with clients like La Caisse and Brookfield shows the firm operating at the intersection of finance, policy and global markets, beyond textbook corporate law.

3. UK & US Market Position

UK

- Magic Circle legacy through Allen & Overy — one of the UK's most prestigious legal brands
- Large London offices with major corporate, finance and regulatory practices

US

- Merger strategically bolsters presence in the lucrative US legal market, where pure UK firms often struggle for scale
- Competes with top US firms (e.g. Kirkland & Ellis, Latham & Watkins) on cross-border deals, US regulatory work, and litigation/arbitration involving multinational clients

USP — Transatlantic Balance

- Unlike firms strong only regionally, A&O Shearman is equally strong in the UK and US
- Genuinely integrates English and U.S. law seamlessly, rather than pushing one jurisdiction's coverage onto the other
- Gives clients true transatlantic capability on complex cross-border deals and disputes
- Lawyers often work on matters spanning multiple legal regimes by default — not merely advising on one jurisdiction alongside local counsel
- Cross-jurisdictional experience is standard, not a niche add-on
- Deep City of London credibility combined with Wall Street/US market credibility

Industry recognition places A&O Shearman within the top tier of global law firms, competing with names like Kirkland & Ellis and Latham & Watkins on complex mandates.

4. Practice Areas (Detailed)

Mergers & Acquisitions

- M&A lawyers work across antitrust, regulatory, capital markets, finance, tax, disputes and foreign direct investment

- Public company advisory and corporate governance group counsels General Counsels and boards on sensitive matters
- Employment, compensation and benefits work, alongside restructuring and insolvency, means the firm can stay with clients through all issues they face across the lifecycle of a deal
- One of the world's leading M&A practices — led deals worth more than £2.2 trillion
- Covers buyouts, mergers, joint ventures, carve-outs, reorganisations; specialised in takeover defence
- Provides advice across the full investment cycle
- Deep industry knowledge (reinforced by MIG and Fuse) supports advisory work
- Builds long-term relationships as trusted advisors
- Advisory strength includes deep knowledge of emerging developments — sustainability, tech, AI
- Provides compliance review and benchmarking for corporate governance policy and annual reporting requirements

Business & Human Rights

- Advisory work helping implement the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights
- Helps clients address changing expectations of stakeholders, investors and regulators
- The disputes team supports human rights due diligence across supply chains, feeding into M&A work
- Example: advised a discount fashion brand on risks associated with suppliers based in countries with high rates of modern slavery

Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)

- Helps companies obtain permission to invest in or acquire companies in other countries
- Some deals raise national security concerns for governments (e.g. a US company buying a UK defence company may be investigated before it is allowed to proceed)
- FDI approval processes are becoming more complex — increased rules, and regulators across different countries increasingly cooperate, meaning several governments may need to approve a single deal
- Lawyers: check whether government approval is needed, prepare applications to regulators, advise on risk, liaise with government during investigations, and help structure deals to secure approval
- Some lawyers previously worked at the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States (CFIUS), giving direct insight into how reviews work and how to get them approved
- Relevant legislation: the National Security and Investment Act

Digital Assets

- Helps companies use new financial technology safely and legally — crypto, digital bonds, NFTs, blockchain-based products
- Because this area is so new, the law is unclear, giving lawyers a significant advisory role right now
- Blockchain = a secure digital record system used to track transactions
- Work includes ensuring technology follows the law, is secure, meets regulatory requirements, and determining whether government approval is needed
- Helps create new digital products such as bonds and blockchain trading platforms, and advises on fraud accusations and regulatory investigations
- Example: advised the European Investment Bank when a group of banks issued a €100m digital bond using blockchain

Bond basics: A bond is a loan from investors to a company, used instead of taking out a large bank loan. Principal = the amount borrowed. Coupon = the interest. Maturity = the time by which it must be repaid.

Sanctions & International Trade

- Helps clients follow international trade rules
- Sanctions = economic restrictions on companies or individuals, e.g. a ban on trading
- Export controls = certain products or technologies (e.g. advanced tech, weapons) require a government licence to export
- Lawyers check for legal risk, identify applicable sanctions or licences needed, and adjust deals to avoid breaching rules
- Example: helped companies withdraw from the Russian market following sanctions imposed after the invasion of Ukraine — reviewing contracts, halting transactions, and restructuring operations
- Ongoing conflicts are likely to lead to further sanctions; the US, EU and UK maintain major sanctions against Iran covering trade and technology
- This creates legal risk for global suppliers — are any suppliers linked to Iran, are goods shipped through sanctioned routes — so the firm helps check deal legality, restructure contracts, and exit sanctioned markets

Private Equity (PE)

- PE firms invest in companies that aren't publicly traded and aim to improve their value over time before selling for a profit
- A&O Shearman advises across the full spectrum: leveraged finance, securitisation, fund finance, and IPOs
- Works with industry teams of expertise across sectors
- Clients benefit from the firm's track record of innovation — it pioneered the use of AI in law, including ContractMatrix, a contract negotiation tool that helps lawyers execute efficiently and focus on the key issues relevant to each deal
- How PE works: firms raise money from investors and wealthy individuals to form a PE fund, then use that capital to buy companies or take them private, typically using a combination of debt and equity (a leveraged buyout)
- "Improving value" can mean cutting costs, improving efficiency, expanding into new markets, or making acquisitions

- The company is then typically sold — via IPO, to another PE firm, or to another company — after roughly 3–7 years

Structured Finance

- Banks or companies bundle up debts (e.g. mortgages, customer receivables) and sell them in packages to investors as an investment product — this is securitisation
- Benefits: more liquid capital for the originator; investors are paid over time with interest, so they receive more than they paid over the long term; and it is a diversified investment, so lower risk

Other Practice Areas

CORPORATE	FINANCE	DISPUTES	ENRI — ENERGY, NATURAL RESOURCES & INFRASTRUCTURE	CAPITAL MARKETS
LEGAL INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY	MARKETS INNOVATION GROUP (MIG)			

Corporate practice advises companies, banks and private equity firms on corporate finance. The firm is fluent in English law, US law, and other global markets, creating a truly global practice.

5. Clients, Industries & Recent Deals

A&O Shearman advises more than a third of NYSE-listed businesses and around a fifth of NASDAQ-listed businesses, as well as many of the world's leading organisations listed on the LSE, Euronext, Euronext Paris, Frankfurt Stock Exchange, Abu Dhabi Securities Exchange, Dubai Financial Market, and the Tokyo and Hong Kong Stock Exchanges.

Clients include major financial institutions, corporations, governments, and stock exchanges.

Six global industry sectors

ENERGY & INFRASTRUCTURE	ESTABLISHED INDUSTRIES	FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS	LIFE SCIENCES	PRIVATE CAPITAL / PRIVATE EQUITY	TECHNOLOGY
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These sectors operate across practices, products and geographies to deepen relationships with organisations worldwide; experienced lawyers also support sub-sectors and additional specific industries. Global practice groups (M&A, Litigation & Investigations, Debt Finance, and others) serve clients on global matters, ensuring collaboration worldwide and a consistent offering across regions. Regional offices focus on local go-to-market strategy, market reputation-building, talent attraction/development, and local operations.

Recent deals & cases

- Advising Froneri on €4.25 billion financing — innovative financing for the next stage of the group's expansion
- Advising Associated British Foods plc on its acquisition of Hovis Group
- Advising the European Investment Bank on issuing digital bonds (helped a group of banks issue a €100m digital bond using blockchain)
- Advising major infrastructure, pensions, private capital and technology clients, including La Caisse and Brookfield — work at the intersection of finance, policy and global markets

6. Global Operating Model

Unlike firms that simply operate multiple offices with separate cultures, A&O Shearman structures its practice groups to work seamlessly across geographies and industries — for example, integrating teams from London, New York, Paris or Singapore on the same matter.

This creates opportunities for apprentices to work with, or be exposed to, international colleagues early; to understand how global teams coordinate on complex matters; and to develop international legal teamwork skills — a niche advantage over more locally focused firms.

- ~50 offices across 29 countries
- ~52% chance of an international secondment
- Regional offices focus on local market strategy, reputation-building, talent development, and local operations

7. Legal Tech & Innovation

A&O Shearman doesn't just use legal technology — it builds legal tech that others use. Its Markets Innovation Group (MIG) combines lawyers, developers and technologists to build tools such as ContractMatrix, an AI-powered contract drafting and negotiation tool developed with Microsoft and Harvey.

This is unusual in the legal world: most firms buy third-party tools, while A&O Shearman creates and commercialises its own — licensing ContractMatrix as software-as-a-service (SaaS), effectively operating part of its innovation function like a tech product company rather than purely a law firm.

Fuse

- Launched in 2017 — the first permanent legal-tech incubator of its kind
- Brings together lawyers, clients and leading tech founders to deliver transformative technology solutions
- Has supported 90+ businesses, contributing to advances in contract automation, AI, data privacy, blockchain and regulatory compliance
- Consistently ranked Band 1 in the "Incubators and Accelerators" category of the Chambers and Partners LawTech Guide — the only

incubator of its kind to be ranked so consistently

- LegalTech stream: invites LegalTech companies globally to join each year; has received 1,400+ applications since launch, including 272 in 2025 alone; selected companies work day-to-day with the firm's lawyers and clients to refine products and accelerate growth

Markets Innovation Group (MIG)

- Leverages in-house tech, flexible resourcing, and shapes the future of the business — described internally as redefining the legal landscape
- Latest innovation: ContractMatrix, built with Harvey and Microsoft, streamlining contract drafting, analysis and negotiation
- Used internally by 2,000+ lawyers; also offered externally to companies on a SaaS basis

Enterprise AI leadership

- First global law firm to deploy generative AI at enterprise scale — training and governing its use across jurisdictions and practice areas
- This isn't just "using AI" — it's leading industry-wide governance models for how lawyers responsibly use generative AI, itself becoming a new legal practice area
- Apprentices joining now enter the early stages of a major industry shift — rare for learners entering law

Believing that robust, trusted, sophisticated advice requires lawyers to understand technology from every angle, the firm's focus on innovation means its lawyers understand how to use, build, deploy and govern these tools.

8. Culture & Values

A deep commitment to excellence, collaboration and innovation underpins the firm's culture. There is reportedly no internal competition — the culture is collaborative, which matters given the integrated global model, where teams need to work together, especially on cross-jurisdiction or cross-sector deals.

- Committed to cultivating a culture where people feel they belong, high performance is sustainable, people's voices are heard, and skills and resources are leveraged to address global and local social and environmental issues
- Underpinned by robust governance to operate the business responsibly and ethically, in balance with the UN Sustainable Development Goals
- Different communities face different issues, challenges and legal frameworks — the firm adapts its approach to local and regional nuances while pursuing a common goal of inclusivity
- Aims to provide an inclusive environment that encourages and welcomes all aspects of everyone's identities
- "Openness is at the heart of our approach. We celebrate our progress and we're honest with ourselves when the progress is not what it should be."
- Ambition extends beyond the firm — aiming to be a leader in driving positive change and demonstrating responsibility across the profession and the communities it serves

Our lawyers have long enjoyed a reputation for cultivating powerful relationships, thriving on seamless collaboration with each other and with their clients, and earning the right to be trusted advisors.

— Firm statement

Trainees report that people support one another and the environment feels collegial rather than hostile. High standards and tight deadlines are matched by genuine collaboration rather than internal competition.

Stated values

- Strong and enduring client relationships
- History of precedent-setting innovation
- Shaping clients' fortunes and applying the law in groundbreaking ways — through innovative thinking or new products, services and technologies

Innovation culture

From Fuse, the tech incubator, to the Markets Innovation Group (MIG), a multidisciplinary team dedicated to developing innovative solutions for client needs, the firm pushes the limits of what a law firm can do — collaborating at the intersection of law, technology and business, and giving early-career lawyers access to an unparalleled network of world-class lawyers and business mentors.

9. Inclusion & Diversity

- Inclusion is positioned as a strategic priority, not branding
- Diversity is framed as making the firm a better adviser to clients, by broadening insight
- Encourages affinity networks open to all employees, supporting communities and fostering learning across groups — including networks for Black lawyers, LGBTQ+ inclusion, women's retention, and race-focused groups, built into the firm's global internal culture rather than treated as afterthoughts
- Has published colleague statistics and specific pay gap reporting, showing a commitment to transparency
- 53% of associates are female

Niche point: having structured global affinity groups that are part of the firm's global inclusivity framework — not just local initiatives — is relatively uncommon among elite law firms, and can be a strong talking point in applications.

Colleague statistics: aoshearman.com/en/about-us/inclusion/london-colleague-statistics

10. Wellbeing & Support

- Counselling and mental health apps available to all staff
- 300+ trained mental health allies globally, helping to normalise conversations and support colleagues
- Structured approach to psychological safety, ensuring people can bring their full selves to work

Niche note: many firms talk about wellbeing, but a global network of trained mental health allies represents a significant operational commitment — showing the firm isn't just paying lip service to the idea.

11. CSR & Sustainability

The firm's pro bono practice is global and multijurisdictional. Lawyers campaign for the protection of fundamental rights, create innovative social finance solutions, support forcibly displaced people, and work on projects to sustain and protect the natural environment.

Key pro bono initiatives

- **Justice Without Borders** — addressing complexities in international litigation to provide legal assistance, compensation and accountability to exploited migrant workers from Indonesia, the Philippines and Singapore
- **Law of Lawmakers** — supporting law reform charity JUSTICE in producing a guide for UK Members of Parliament explaining key legal and constitutional principles they will encounter in their work
- **Women for Women International** — studying the impact of women's movements on international peace agreements, informing the organisation's strategy on live conflicts and future peace processes
- **Public International Law and Policy Group (PILPG)** — cross-border teams working on matters relating to peace agreements and post-conflict reconstruction/transitional justice in The Gambia and elsewhere
- **Women's Livelihood Bond™** — supporting the Impact Investment Exchange in structuring and selling an innovative series of blended finance instruments designed to empower three million under-served women in developing countries

Environmental commitments

- Committed to achieving net zero carbon emissions by 2050 through operational measures and supply chain engagement
- Science Based Targets: halve global direct and indirect (Scope 1, 2 and 3) greenhouse gas emissions by 2030 against a 2019 baseline
- Reports to EcoVadis; obtained a CDP "B" rating in the 2024 disclosure cycle for the first time — recognition of addressing environmental impact and ensuring good environmental governance

12. Awards & Recognition

- **World's Most Innovative Law Firm** — Financial Times Innovative Lawyer Global Summit, London, 24 June 2025
- David Wakeling, partner and head of the firm's AI advisory practice, named one of the top 20 legal innovators of the past two decades

13. Apprenticeship Programme Structure

This new legal apprenticeship initiative builds on A&O Shearman's successful 12-year apprenticeship programme, which currently supports 34 apprentices across marketing, finance, IT and Human Resources functions. Through this four/six-year legal apprenticeship with a university partner (Ulster University / BPP University, depending on cohort), successful candidates gain an LLB — a qualifying law degree enabling further legal training and career opportunities. Apprentices also join the firm's Emerging Talent Programme, designed to enhance skills, foster professional growth, and prepare them to become valuable members of the firm.

We strive for excellence in all that we do and recognise the significant benefits our apprenticeship programme brings. We are committed to providing apprentices with the support and resources they need to thrive in their studies and future careers.

— Firm statement

To date, more than 85% of those who have completed their apprenticeships with A&O Shearman in Belfast secure full-time roles with the firm and remain valued members of our team. This pathway delivers internationally recognised qualifications and reduces the financial burden of rising university fees.

— Firm / university partnership statement

Salary

£32,000 in the first year of the apprenticeship (increasing every year) is cited for the Solicitor Apprenticeship programme in some materials; the specific role referenced in this pack is advertised at £28,000 + £3,000 sign-on. Check the live listing for the current figure.

Years 1-4 (or 1-5, depending on cohort): study & rotation

- One day a week at BPP University studying: the English Legal System, Client Care, Contract Law, Legal Research, Tort Law, Land

Law, one of Dispute Resolution/Property Practice/Commercial Practice, Public Law, Criminal Law, Company Law, Trusts Law, and Wills and Administration of Estates

- Coaching and skills development training at BPP University, including Client Care, Legal Research, Professional Conduct, a Professional Practice Skills module at each stage, Working with People and Processes, Ethics and Professionalism, Research and Analysis, and Advocacy and Negotiation
- Dedicated supervisors and other points of contact throughout, to ensure the best possible pastoral care
- In the first three years, apprentices are a member of one legal department, rotating once a year, with the opportunity to rotate practice groups within each department for greater breadth
- Experience spans Finance, Corporate, ENRI (Energy, Natural Resources & Infrastructure), and Disputes departments
- Each year, apprentices work for different members of the department for varied experience, with the security of a training principal to guide them
- Depending on department, apprentices may work closely with other teams such as Fuse (the tech innovation hub), the Markets Innovation Group, Legal Tech, eDiscovery, or Project Management teams

Years 5-6: SQE & secondment

- Focus shifts to SQE preparation and examinations at BPP University
- Seat rotations mirror the graduate trainee population
- The firm aims to provide secondment opportunities during the solicitor apprenticeship programme (to clients or other A&O Shearman offices)

What apprentices gain

- Hands-on experience in an industry-leading law firm
- Practical skills and knowledge, working on real projects, live deals, and challenging client cases
- Exceptional training and mentorship from experienced legal professionals
- Potential secondment opportunity (to clients or other offices) during the apprenticeship
- Learning from industry-leading experts and applying learning to live matters and deals
- Discovering new options and tailoring a path to their interests
- Support to integrate fully — "people go above and beyond to ensure apprentices are integrated"
- Working alongside and learning from aspirational, highly capable colleagues

Apprentice stories (themes raised by current apprentices)

- Seeing your name in the lawyer newsletter after working on a big deal
- Seeing the real impact of your own work
- Everyone is different, and that difference is valued
- A sense of finding "your people" and the right place within the firm
- Access to people who have done what you're doing and can offer advice
- A sense that the profession is being reimaged, and that young people are needed to help it evolve

14. Skills & Values Sought

Core values

- **Ambition** — determined to achieve a first-class legal career and tackle challenges along the way
- **Collaboration** — enjoys working in a team to complete a task or achieve a shared goal
- **Resilience** — able to respond to pressure and overcome challenges constructively
- **Passion** — welcomes applicants passionate about commercial law and innovation, regardless of university or degree background

When reviewing applicants, the firm looks for the skills and qualities that will help someone become a talented lawyer — not just strong communication and organisational skills, but the commitment, resilience and enthusiasm required to be an effective team member and work under pressure. Because a career in law can be challenging, apprentices need to be adaptable and able to work effectively both individually and as part of a team.

What truly defines a career with us? We recruit the best and ask for the best of you. And together, we will redefine success.

— Firm statement

Additional themes: thinking creatively and entrepreneurially; pushing boundaries and building for the future; meeting and exceeding the highest standards; working on complex, cross-border deals; being a market leader that finds new ways of meeting evolving client challenges; a future-focused, digital mindset; reimagining what law looks like tomorrow; capitalising on constant change; challenging and rewarding assignments.

15. Application Advice (From a Firm Contact)

It may come as no surprise that the application process can be long and arduous — the overarching advice is not to let that compromise your studies and grades, since these ultimately secure your place come results day.

Secondly, and this may sound counterintuitive — look at a range of options, both other firms and other careers. The six-year commitment is a long one.

In terms of standing out in an application, the most important things are: (i) showing why you're interested in the given firm specifically — anyone can give a generic answer, but what is it that really means you want to work for this firm; and (ii) demonstrating the core qualities of the role within your experience descriptions. Rather than simply stating you work well in a team, show specifically what you've done that demonstrates this. Attention to detail also matters — make sure spelling and structure are on point.

Outside of this, getting a range of experience (not necessarily legal) should be a focus — insight days, online Forage simulations, and part-time jobs of any nature are all valuable.

16. Webinar Notes — 26 January

- Magic Circle, global elite law firm — deeper insight into the industry from the firm's perspective
- Described as the world's largest, fully integrated, unique transatlantic platform
- 50% of the world's legal spend occurs in the US, which was a key driver behind the merger
- Many cross-border disputes make it attractive for clients to use one firm for all their deals
- Firm description: "human in nature but bold in reach"
- 750 partners, with clear progression routes; 250 years of combined expertise
- Roughly 30% of the firm is US-based, 40% rest-of-world
- Unmatched global reach, trainee exposure, and networking connections, including partnerships in non-office countries
- Scale-up and consistent quality across markets; full-service offering
- Advanced delivery and solutions teams drive innovation in project management
- Early adopters of Harvey AI; ContractMatrix built in-house
- Global business teams spanning HR, finance and operations
- Work experience (WEX) is seen as valuable life experience in its own right — including the firm's virtual WEX programme
- Specific practice areas were highlighted, alongside the importance of attention to detail when reviewing work, and explaining your work clearly and concisely
- Key interview theme: what has motivated you to pursue a career in commercial law, what work experience you've done, and what steps you've taken to explore the decision

Context on the merger and market position (from wider notes)

- Market-leading banking and finance practice — Band 1 for a market worth over \$7 trillion
- Described as the most internationally reaching firm of any Magic Circle firm — e.g. able to advise on China's distinct regulatory regime for its bond market due to its jurisdictional capabilities
- Strong corporate M&A practice, reinforced by the merger — e.g. Virgin Group/Nationwide's acquisition of Virgin Money
- Described as a technologically driven firm — e.g. tools that automatically update interest rates and track certain assets
- The merger has expanded sector choice and created larger teams, supporting better collaboration, meeting people, and learning to delegate and supervise work
- Trainees report learning a lot from pro bono work; the merger has also expanded pro bono opportunities
- Larger teams are seen as good for meeting new people across the firm and choosing sectors of interest
- Knowledge teams: specialised lawyers who stay up to date with legal change, acting as a resource to call upon

17. Personal Fit & Application Angles

Drafted talking points connecting personal motivations to the firm's positioning — for use/refinement in application answers.

A&O Shearman as a firm built for complexity

What particularly attracts me to A&O Shearman is that it was formed through the merger of two firms with complementary strengths, creating a practice designed for the most complex, cross-border legal work. This signals a firm that actively embraces structural change and long-term strategic thinking rather than maintaining the status quo. I am motivated by environments where adaptability, collaboration and commercial judgement are essential, and where legal advice must operate seamlessly across jurisdictions, industries and regulatory frameworks.

Why this stands out: most candidates mention the merger — this explains why it matters commercially and culturally.

Apprenticeship as commercial training, not just legal training

The solicitor apprenticeship stands out because it develops apprentices as commercial professionals as well as future solicitors. Working on live matters while studying law builds understanding not only of legal principles, but of how those principles support client decision-making, risk management and strategic outcomes — aligning with how modern legal services operate as part of a wider commercial ecosystem, rather than in isolation.

AI-friendly skills flagged: commercial awareness, risk management, strategic thinking, client focus.

Early responsibility as a measure of trust

I am particularly drawn to A&O Shearman's approach of giving apprentices meaningful responsibility on real client matters from an early stage. This demonstrates a high level of trust in early talent and reflects a culture that values accountability, precision and professional maturity. Being trusted with real work is the most effective way to develop attention to detail, judgement and resilience — skills essential in a firm operating at the highest level.

Why this is rare: framing responsibility as a cultural signal, not a perk.

Global mindset without losing precision

A&O Shearman's global reach is compelling because it combines international scale with technical precision. Advising on cross-border matters requires not only strong legal analysis, but clear communication, cultural awareness, and the ability to coordinate across teams and jurisdictions — the kind of environment in which I would thrive, since it demands clarity of thought and disciplined execution.

Commitment to early talent as a strategic investment

Initiatives such as Smart Start and the structured solicitor apprenticeship show that A&O Shearman views early talent development as a long-term investment rather than a short-term pipeline. This aligns with my own approach to professional development: building strong foundations early, seeking feedback, and continuously improving in high-expectation environments.

Subtle signal: coachable, long-term focused, self-directed.

Why I fit A&O Shearman

I am motivated by environments that combine intellectual challenge with high standards and accountability. A&O Shearman's culture of excellence, collaboration and commercial focus aligns closely with how I approach my academic studies, work experience, and responsibilities outside school. I am particularly drawn to a firm where apprentices are expected to think critically, act professionally, and contribute meaningfully from the outset.

Additional personal reflections

- Long working hours and the level of commitment involved is something I enjoy
- Assessment across social life, tech, quality of work and training all come out strongly positive relative to smaller, less prestigious UK firms
- I feel I would get a quality of work that smaller, less prestigious UK-based firms could not offer
- I thrive being trusted with responsibility, and genuinely enjoy meeting tight deadlines, high standards, and constantly improving
- Notably, there is no internal competition — it's collaborative, which matters given the integrated global model, where teams need to work together, especially on cross-jurisdiction or cross-sector deals
- I like that the firm profiles its leadership and executive team openly on its website

Sources: A&O Shearman careers site and colleague statistics disclosures; equalopportunitiescareers.co.uk profile; firm webinar (26 January); Financial Times Innovative Lawyer Global Summit coverage; firm press releases. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.